



THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO

#2024ELECTION: AN EXPLORATORY ANALYSIS OF
POLITICULTURAL COMMUNITIES ON TIKTOK

By
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Abstract

This thesis explores how cultural discourse varies in both structure and content across political party lines on TikTok. To answer this question, I take presidential candidate accounts as partisan representations and examine the TikTok videos reposted by followers of candidate accounts. To analyze the TikTok repost data, I employ frequent itemset mining, social network analysis, and BERTopic modeling. I find that the semantic communities in Trump followers' reposts are more overlapping and less distinct than those found in Harris followers' reposts. I find that Harris followers' reposts cover a wider breadth of topics. I analyze several emergent themes in the content of the reposts, finding connections to gender, sexuality, and violence. These findings corroborate current literature surrounding American partisanship, culture, and social media. I discuss how TikTok mediates and produces culture, indicating that future research is needed to understand the political relevance and impact of the social media platform.

Keywords: social media, TikTok, politics, partisan, election, culture, social network analysis, frequent itemset mining, association rule mining, topic modeling

1 Introduction

On June 7th, 2024, electric pop music artist Charli XCX released her hit album BRAT, which received wide acclaim and garnered huge commercial success. Later that summer, then-Vice President Kamala Harris announced the beginning of her presidential campaign for the upcoming 2024 U.S. Presidential Election. The two seemingly unrelated events would come to intertwine on the social media app and platform TikTok, as a strange remix of Charli XCX's song Apple incorporating an audio clip of Harris speaking at a press conference exploded in popularity (Clarke-Billings, 2024).¹ In order for this bizarre combination of politics and music to skyrocket into virality, there needed to be some overlap in the groups of TikTok users who knew of Charli XCX and users who knew of former Vice

¹As of writing, the most-liked TikTok post playing this "Coconut" remix of Charli XCX's "Apple" has over 6.7 million views and over 1.2 million likes total.

President Kamala Harris. The question remains: to what extent do these cultural and political communities intersect, and does this vary by political party? For this research proposal, I explore TikTok to ask if partisan preference is associated with difference in culture and entertainment preferences on the platform. This can be broken down into two main research questions:

RQ 1: How do the semantic and cultural communities of Democrats and Republicans on TikTok differ structurally?

RQ 2: How do the the topics and contents of these communities compare across Democrats and Republicans on TikTok?

2 Literature Review

2.1 Politics, Attitudes, and Preferences

It is well documented in previous literature that political attitudes and preferences permeate deeply and widely into individual’s social lives and identities. Policultural sorting, or the fragmentation of American cultures along political affiliation, is demonstrated in one study that uses National Consumer Survey data to show liberal and conservative ideology each encompass multiple cultural archetypes (Rogers, 2022). Another study finds that liberals and conservatives from the same college campus spend their time differently in small but robust ways, physically occupying separate geographic spaces (Talaifar et al., 2025). This effect was more strongly observed for individuals’ leisure time; furthermore, there is a difference in the way that Democrats and Republicans perceive content on social media platforms (Talaifar et al., 2025) (McClain et al., 2024). Not only is this cultural and behavioral partisanship exhibited by individuals, but individuals can also recognize this partisanship in others. Studies have shown that individuals can correctly identify others’ political affiliations using non-political cues and information, such as one’s preferences in music or clothing (Deichert, 2019) (Lee, 2021). Perhaps more importantly, individuals use these inferences on political affiliation to decide whom to interact with, which can further encourage in-group interaction and cause more cleavage between parties (Deichert, 2019) (Lee, 2021).

The policultural divide extends to social media preferences and behaviors as well. One study shows that political polarization extends to brand-preference polarization on Twitter following the 2016 and 2020 Presidential election (Schoenmueller et al., 2023). Individuals who engage in partisan spheres on social media exhibit different patterns of interaction compared to non-partisans (Mamakos & Finkel, 2023); user behavior on social media also varies by party, even when the topic at hand is not inherently related to politics (Pendse et al., 2025) (Essig & DellaPosta, 2024). Opinions and perception of social media

platforms vary by party, TikTok included (McClain et al., 2024). Political activists and elites have grown their presence and messaging on TikTok, establishing the app as a platform of relevance in ongoing and future movements and elections (Moir, 2023) (Abbas et al., 2022) (Cervi & Divon, 2023). This difference in culture and behaviors along partisan lines, on social media and otherwise, along with partisan differences in perceptions of TikTok, suggest that TikTok usage is likely to vary by political preference. With recent shifts in the American political landscape, such as the increased influence of far-right politics and affective polarization (Brown et al., 2023) (Polacko, 2022), it is likely that this political divide is also shifting. TikTok may be a platform with unique insight to analyze this shift, given its recent popularity and increased political relevance with American youth (McClain et al., 2024). However, literature surrounding TikTok is currently sparse, and more disconcertingly, easily outdated, due to the temporal and rapidly-evolving structure of the platform.

2.2 TikTok and Its Eccentricities

One particularity of TikTok as a social media platform is how unrepresentative its users are of the broader American public; a prevalent feature of the app is the extent to which it appeals to younger users. This particularism flows bidirectionally; TikTok has shown to be more politically influential for young adults than other social media platforms, and there is also a disproportionately larger share of younger users on TikTok than other age groups in comparison to other social media platforms (Karimi & Fox, 2023) (McClain et al., 2024). Not only is the app more widely used by youth, there is evidence that TikTok usership is predictive of higher rates of civic engagement and in-person activism efforts (Karimi & Fox, 2023) (Oden & Porter, 2023). Adolescents and young adults also seem to be more proficient at communicating on TikTok, leveraging their knowledge of algorithmic patterns and “algospeak” to bypass content moderation of certain keywords or topics (Steen et al., 2023). This new form of communication contrasts with the linguistic structure of traditional media outlets such as news stations and journals, and as such there is a clear generational divide on the app.

With this clear emphasis on rapidly evolving slang and equally temporal trends, it is no mystery why much of the extant literature on TikTok and politics surrounds youth organizing and the way TikTok’s communication differs from other social media platforms (Abbas et al., 2022) (Cervi & Divon, 2023) (Hindarto, 2022). However, the shape of the overall political landscape remains largely unclear; though some studies report a liberal or left-biased slant for the overall spread of content on TikTok and its user demographic (McClain et al., 2024) (Karimi & Fox, 2023), other studies claim that in terms of total output, right-wing political content prevails (Widholm et al., 2024) (Medina Serrano et

al., 2020). As the platform grew in popularity, politicians and political bases began to adopt TikTok as a means of reaching voters and constituents (Moir, 2023), with interesting implications as to how posts such as “thirst traps” and various “TikTok style edits” can influence the perception of politicians by the public (Munger & Li, 2025), highlighting the salience of structure and format in political communication on TikTok.

2.3 The Gap In Literature

Past scholarship has utilized these unique structures of communication on TikTok to examine interactions not found on other social media platforms. Its growing popularity has also enabled scale-up of research studies that would not have been possible just years prior. For example, Medina Serrano et al. (2020) used a web crawler to collect videos, which were then analyzed using Microsoft’s Azure Face API. Another group of researchers trained a neural network to classify TikTok videos filmed in second person view and non-second person points of view in order to compare engagement differences between the two types of videos Cheng and Li, 2024 . Other computational researchers took advantage of TikTok’s Research Tools API, including one such group of researchers who analyzed political discourse surrounding the 2024 election prior to former President Joe Biden’s withdrawal (Pinto et al., 2024). Another study made use of Amazon’s Mechanical Turk to administer a large-scale survey, highlighting another computational method that deviates from what otherwise has been a predominantly qualitative body of research on TikTok (Karimi & Fox, 2023) (Hindarto, 2022) (Kanthawala et al., 2022).

My research project is aimed at filling the gap between the study of politics on TikTok and politics in relation to other facets of social life. This thesis aims to strike at the intersection of the ongoing shifts in politics, culture, and entertainment on TikTok, which is of emerging salience. I will additionally make use of computational methods for data collection and analysis, which is an underexplored and undersaturated area in researching TikTok. Other scholars have laid groundwork in similar methods for different domains; Shi et al. (2017) conducted a conceptually similar study by analyzing the relationship between political affiliation and interest in science through Amazon book purchase history, connecting political affiliation to other aspects of individual identity. We have ample literature on the structure of the platform, the rhetorical and linguistic strategies employed in political communication, and of TikTok’s unique relationship with youth; what remains unknown is how the bi-partite cultural networks of TikTok users differ in their structure and contents. In my next section, I will take advantage of TikTok’s platform structure in building a dataset to examine this very question.

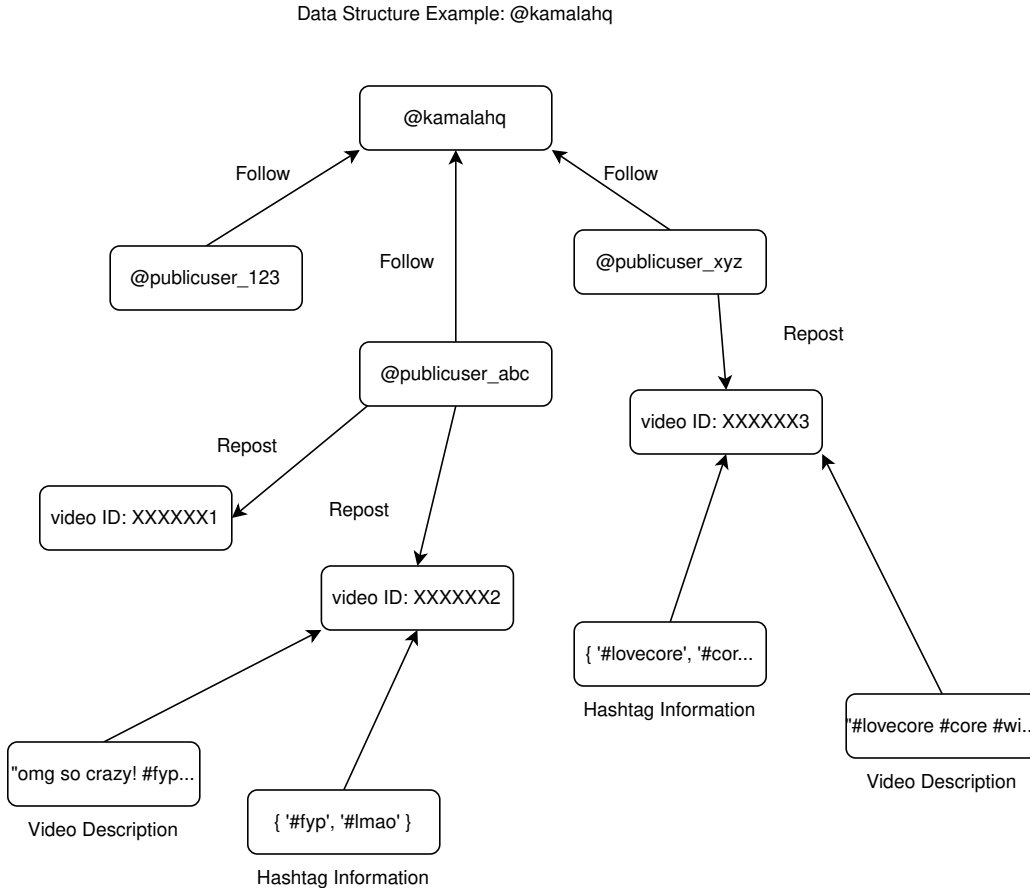


Figure 1: Dataset structure, using @kamalahq as the example campaign TikTok account.

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Data Structure

Using the TikTok API, I queried and obtained all the data required for analysis. The dataset for this study branches out in a tree-like structure, shown in Figure 1. I first identified official platform-verified TikTok campaign accounts for Harris and Trump, which are @kamalahq and @teamtrump, respectively. I then collected the usernames of the accounts that most recently followed each campaign account as of December 23, 2025. The ambiguity in time range is a result of the forced backwards pagination design in the API, which allows me to access only the most recently added followers. I was able to collect 462 follower usernames for @kamalahq and 511 follower usernames for @teamtrump for a total of 973 TikTok users. These two groups of users are disjoint; each user in this dataset follows only one of the two campaign accounts. The difference in numbers is due to various types of missingness or redaction in the data collection process, which includes deleted accounts,

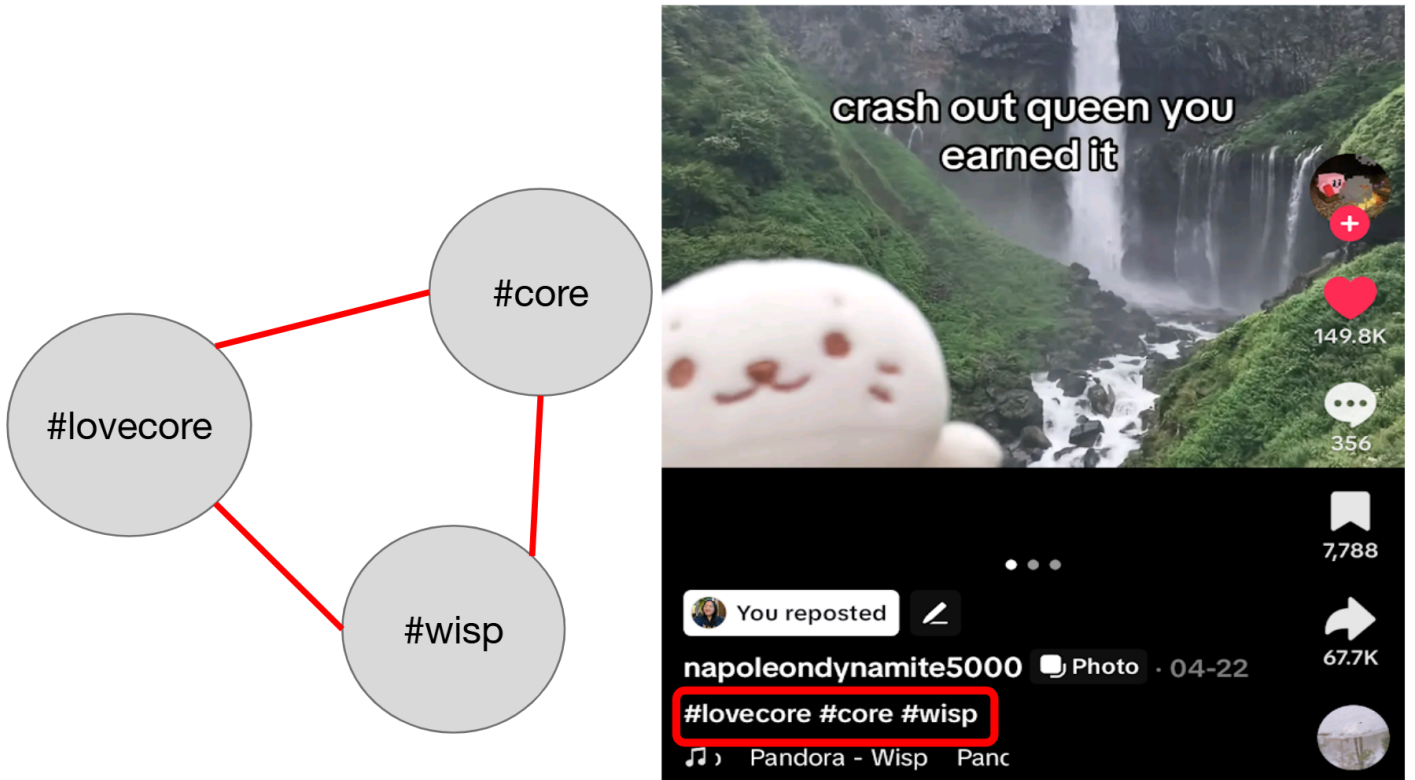


Figure 2: A scaled down example of constructing the co-hashtag network, where each TikTok repost constitutes an edge between any two hashtags in the video description.

underage accounts, and private accounts. As of the time of writing, the TikTok Research Tools API documentation lists the aforementioned reasons as potential causes of missingness, but also notes that other unaccounted factors can cause missingness. Therefore, the difference in size between the two groups of followers could be caused by systemic or random differences.

After constructing the dataset of campaign account public followers, I scraped the metadata of each reposted TikTok video from each of the 973 users, resulting in 1,298,363 Harris follower reposts and 402,861 Trump follower reposts. The video metadata I use in my analysis are the video descriptions, which is the text shown at the bottom of a video, and the hashtags, which are a list of hashtags found within the video description. Though hashtags are contained within video descriptions, I use both hashtags and video descriptions in my analysis because some methods, like network modeling, are better suited to hashtags, whereas other methods, such as document embeddings, are better suited to video description text.

3.2 Methods

Using this dataset, I perform three different methods of analysis. The first two methods focus on substantive analysis of TikTok videos, whereas the third method is focused on a structural analysis. The first method I use is itemset mining, drawing inspiration again from Shi et al. (2017), where researchers take advantage of Amazon’s suggested co-purchase itemsets regarding online book sales. Itemset mining, or association rule mining, is suited to analyzing frequently co-occurring items. Due to the large scale of my dataset, I use a Frequent Pattern Growth (FP-Growth) algorithm as designed by Han et al. (2000) to reduce computational costs. I apply FP-Growth itemset mining to the TikTok videos reposted by the followers of @kamalahq and @teamtrump by analyzing each video as a set of co-occurring hashtags. One benefit of itemset mining is that it is directional and therefore distinguishes between symmetrically and asymmetrically implicative relationships amongst items in a set. For example, the frequent itemset $[\#billieilish \rightarrow \#edit]$ demonstrates that in posts where $\#billieilish$ is tagged, $\#edit$ is also frequently tagged, but it does not imply that $\#billieilish$ is frequently tagged in posts containing $\#edit$. In this regard, association rules not only produce macro-level insights on the general pattern of hashtag associations, but also allow micro-level substantive analysis by contextualizing hashtags within association rules.

For my second method of analysis I construct a hashtag co-occurrence network to see how ideas within these partisan spaces relate to each other. In this weighted network, each node represents a unique hashtag, and each edge between two hashtags represents the number of times the two hashtags co-occur in the TikTok reposts. For an example, refer to Figure 2. Using network-level analysis measures, I compare the two networks to each other. Measures such as density, clustering coefficient, and degree assortativity will reveal insight into the shape of the networks; measures such as diameter, number of nodes, and number of edges will provide a basis of comparison on size. I also examine nodes of interest and prestige using degree centrality, betweenness centrality, and pagerank centrality to identify hashtags that may be indicative or representative of popular topics. The mixture of network-level measures and hashtag-level measures gives both structural and substantive understanding of the corpus and helps to connect the semantic meanings of hashtags themselves to their relative positions in the network.

Finally, for my third method of analysis, I turn towards interpreting the contents of TikTok posts that were reposted by followers of @kamalahq and @teamtrump. Using the video description text of TikTok reposts as documents, I fit a mixed deep-learning and unsupervised learning BERTopic clustering pipeline for each candidate’s followers’ text (Groendorst, 2022). However, it would be too computationally expensive to fit the topic model on the entirety of the text. Instead, I perform a grid search over bootstrap samples and

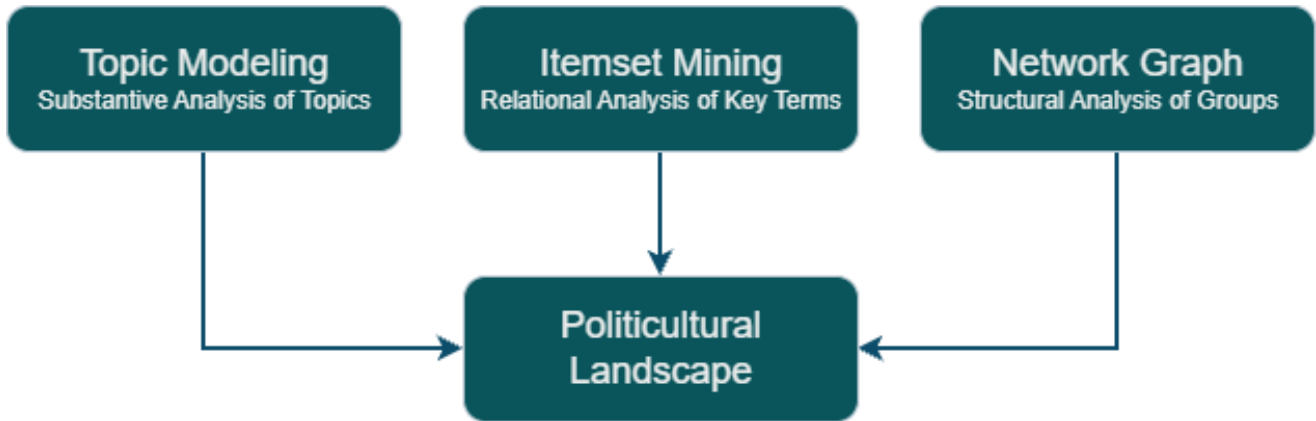


Figure 3: The contributions of the three different analytical methods towards one main goal.

compare each iteration’s out-of-bootstrap-sample silhouette score, pair-wise topic cosine similarity, and number of topics. I select the iteration with the highest silhouette score that contains between 15 and 30 topics to qualitatively interpret the contents of the corpus. Using the distributions of silhouette scores and pair-wise topic cosine similarity, I compare the two follower bases’ discursive structure. By examining the resulting topic clusters, I can infer intra-topic and inter-topic heterogeneity and the relative distances between topic clusters. I evaluate the quality of topics by using silhouette score, which broadly measures the distance of documents to their own topic’s centroid against the distance to centroids of other topics. I further examine the distribution of topics by comparing average pair-wise topic cosine similarity in a statistical test, which will give insight to the spread and diversity of topics.

These analyses all help to fill out the substantive and structural landscape of the politicultural divide on TikTok. While itemset mining can identify crucial hashtag tokens and relationships, network analysis can provide insight into larger community structure. Finally, topic modeling provides a corpus-level substantive summary of the corpus contents. Using combined methods create a comprehensive picture of the politicultural landscape by providing insight to different facets of socialization: the stuffing, the scaffolding, and the sinew.

3.3 Concerns and Critiques

The most concerning weakness of this analysis is the non-representative data and data missingness. The follower dataset that I gathered is not a random sample of all of the followers of @kamalahq and @teamtrump. Furthermore, the followers collected are recent followers, meaning they followed the campaign accounts roughly a year after the end of

the election. This may confound some of the results and reduce generalizability, as there may be underlying systematic bias in either the missingness or the range of data collected itself. For example, if the follower groups of @kamalahq and @teamtrump are growing at different rates,² we might interpret the gathered followers of the faster growing candidate to be more recently followed, and perhaps also newer, accounts, which may explain a sparser or shorter reposting history. Due to the opacity of the TikTok Research API tools, it is further difficult to differentiate between types of missingness or to identify missingness at all; this imagined hole is of unknown shape, size, and dimension. As such, I take great care in interpreting results and ground my findings in the context of current literature. Further research is necessary to expand the scope and improve the robustness of claims.

There is also the theoretical concern of how politics and political attitudes are framed. Insofar as the Democratic Party espouses liberal politics and the Republican Party is considered conservative, we might also extend these labels to the users who follow the accounts of the party leaders with little doubt; however, that would be an oversight of the shifting political spectrum of American politics. Affective polarization has consolidated partisan division for both the public and for elites (Iyengar et al., 2019) (Flamino et al., 2023), but public opinion itself can be cued by party policy attitudes (Yeung & Quek, 2025). Thus, the true relationship between an individual’s ideology and party identity is difficult to assess, and furthermore neither extractable from my data nor relevant to the research question. While I draw upon literature that examines ideology, for the purposes of this thesis, I reduce political attitudes to partisanship, wherever these parties may fall on a political spectrum. As such, I will not attempt to dissect the ideologies of these parties, but rather allow parties to exist as their own entity and observe them as a generative collective with their own cultures and interests.

Finally, there is the issue of interpreting a user following a campaign TikTok account as support or preference for the candidate’s party. It is not certain that individuals who only follow one of the two major party candidates support that party and that candidate. Short of combing through all of the followers’ profiles, following is a more consistent behavioral heuristic compared to commenting, liking, and reposting. The latter options are sporadic behaviors that need to be evaluated in their volume and frequency; with commenting, the textual data would need to be analyzed, which can be difficult with brief comments or comments that reference pop culture. By drawing upon the pool of followers, I can create a well-defined sample that is not prone to inconsistent behavior.

²This is probable, seeing as at the time of writing, @kamalahq has 5.5 million followers while @teamtrump has 13.6 million followers.

4 Results

My analysis of TikTok reposts indicate several crucial findings. Firstly, Harris followers repost more frequently and richly compared to Trump followers; in addition to a higher average number of reposts, Harris reposts have a higher average number of hashtags per repost. Secondly, Trump followers have denser and higher connectivity semantic communities than Harris followers. Finally, the difference in content between Harris and Trump follower reposts reveal some interesting cultural patterns. In the following sections, I show an in-depth examination for each of my analysis methods.

4.1 Frequent Itemset Mining

Metric	Harris	Trump
Total Reposts	1,298,363	402,861
Total Hashtags	6,259,496	1,870,552
Unique Hashtags	468,933	227,749
Avg Hashtags per Repost	4.82	4.64

Table 1: Descriptive statistics of the hashtag corpus used for frequent itemset mining. Note that there are nearly three times as many reposts from Harris followers compared to reposts from Trump followers.

Upon first glance, it appears that Harris’s followers have a richer and larger corpus of TikTok repost hashtags. Table 1 shows a preliminary hashtag overview. Despite there being fewer Harris followers in the dataset, there are roughly three times as many TikTok videos reposted by the Harris followers compared to Trump followers. The Harris follower corpus additionally has more than twice as many unique hashtag tokens compared to the Trump follower corpus, and each repost on average contains more hashtags. Harris followers repost and thereby endorse TikTok content more frequently, and the content they repost are also richer in hashtags.

There are several measures to consider when evaluating the validity and insightfulness of association rules. The first is confidence, which is defined as:

$$\text{conf}(I \rightarrow j) = P(j|I) = \frac{P(I,j)}{P(I)} = \text{support}(I \cap j) / \text{support}(I)$$

which measures the extent to which the antecedent item, I , implies the consequent item, j . If the confidence of the association rule $[\text{\#billieeilish} \rightarrow \text{\#edit}]$ is 0.80, then 80% of all posts containing $\text{\#billieeilish}$ also contain $\text{\#edit}$. This is a general measure of how strongly associated these two items are. Another measure to consider is lift, which is defined as follows:

$$\text{lift}(I \rightarrow j) = \frac{\text{conf}(I \rightarrow j)}{(P(j))}$$

which is the ratio that measures the magnitude to which I amplifies or “lifts” the likelihood of j . If the lift of $[\#billieeilish \rightarrow \#edit]$ is 2.5, then $\#edit$ is 2.5 times as likely to be tagged if $\#billieeilish$ is also tagged.

Figure 4 displays the highest confidence association rules found after FP-Growth itemset mining. This offers a glimpse into the discourse patterns for each candidate’s follower group. Pop music artist Billie Eilish and her sophomore album, *HIT ME HARD AND SOFT*, abbreviated as “hmhas”, dominate the high confidence association rules in the Harris hashtags. Eilish is joined on this list by her peer Sabrina Carpenter, another pop music artist, whose album *Short n’ Sweet* won the 2025 Grammy Award for *Album of the Year* and *Best Pop Vocal Album* (Frazier, 2025). Ilya Rozanov and Shane Hollander, fictional hockey players from the novel and recently adapted television show, *Heated Rivalry*, also make appearances in high confidence association rules.

The patterns found in high confidence association rules in Trump hashtags are not quite as concrete and specific. The majority of the association rules are connected to the hashtag ‘#fyp’, which is an abbreviation of “For You Page.” The For You Page on TikTok is akin to an explore or discovery page that has been attuned to the user’s preferences and engagement patterns. The hashtag ‘#fyp’ therefore does not provide information about the contents of the TikTok post but rather indicates the post creator’s desire to increase the chances of the post being shown on other users’ For You Pages. Variations of ‘#fyp’ include tags such as ‘#foryou’, ‘#foryoupage’, ‘#fypage’, and more. Other tags such as ‘#trend’ and ‘#viral’ are used to increase a post’s visibility and are functionally similar to ‘#fyp’. I will refer to these hashtags as *engagement hacking hashtags*. Aside from engagement hacking hashtags, there are a few references to media and entertainment in the high confidence association rules. For example, the hashtag ‘#asap’ generally refers to rapper A\$AP Rocky rather than “as soon as possible.” The fiction book series *Dexter* and its multiple television adaptations are also featured, as well as the science fiction television show *Doctor Who*.³

Notice also in Figure 5 that ‘#fyp’ is actually tagged at a higher frequency in Harris follower reposts than in Trump follower reposts; despite ‘#fyp’ having higher overall support in the Harris corpus, the frequent itemsets containing ‘#fyp’ have a tighter association in the Trump corpus. Other notable hashtags in the figure show which hashtags, while not occurring in the association rules, are more associated with which party. For example, ‘#cars’, ‘#fortnite’,⁴ and ‘#football’ occur more frequently in Trump follower reposts,

³The English actor Matt Smith portrays the character of the 11th Doctor in the television series. Curiously, the 10th Doctor also makes an appearance in the high confidence association rules, but the actor who portrays him, David Tennant, does not.

⁴Fortnite is a popular video game

Harris Association Rules, High Confidence						Trump Association Rules, High Confidence					
The top 30 highest confidence association rules						The top 30 highest confidence association rules					
antecedent	consequent	confidence	lift	support		antecedent	consequent	confidence	lift	support	
[‘hmhas’, ‘edit’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.993	55.793	0.0006		[‘mattsmith’]	[‘doctorwho’]	0.973	449.051	0.0005	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘billieeilishedits’, ‘edit’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.99	55.639	0.0005		[‘formulaone’, ‘formula1’]	[‘f1’]	0.972	228.892	0.0005	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘edit’, ‘viral’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.988	55.516	0.0007		[‘trend’, ‘trending’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.969	2.404	0.0011	
[‘shortnsweet’, ‘fyp’]	[‘sabinacarpenter’]	0.987	253.173	0.0005		[‘dexteredit’, ‘dextermorgan’]	[‘dexter’]	0.965	248.228	0.0007	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘edit’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.987	55.458	0.0013		[‘cars’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.962	2.386	0.0005	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘foryou’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.985	55.379	0.0008		[‘trend’, ‘trending’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.96	2.38	0.0007	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘edit’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.985	55.356	0.0019		[‘10thdoctor’]	[‘doctorwho’]	0.96	442.805	0.0006	
[‘eilish’, ‘billieeilishedits’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.984	55.337	0.0007		[‘asap’]	[‘asaprocky’]	0.957	433.947	0.0005	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘billie’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.984	55.334	0.0005		[‘trend’, ‘trending’, ‘foryoupage’]	[‘fyp’]	0.952	2.362	0.0013	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘edit’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.983	55.279	0.0012		[‘trend’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.952	2.362	0.0009	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘billieeilishedits’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.983	55.233	0.0011		[‘fypage’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.95	2.356	0.0008	
[‘ilyarozanov’, ‘shanehollander’]	[‘heatedrivalry’]	0.982	499.423	0.0007		[‘edit’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.949	2.354	0.0011	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘aftereffects’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.981	55.16	0.0005		[‘love’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’]	[‘fyp’]	0.947	2.35	0.0009	
[‘hmhas’, ‘viral’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.981	55.15	0.0006		[‘goviral’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.946	2.347	0.0006	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘edit’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.981	55.142	0.0009		[‘xyzbca’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.946	2.346	0.001	
[‘hmastour’, ‘hmhas’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.98	55.104	0.0007		[‘ichigo’, ‘anime’]	[‘bleach’]	0.942	252.953	0.0009	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘foryou’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.98	55.098	0.0011		[‘tiktok’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.941	2.335	0.0009	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘billieeilishedits’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.98	55.059	0.0007		[‘trend’, ‘trending’, ‘foryou’]	[‘fyp’]	0.94	2.332	0.001	
[‘ilyarozanov’]	[‘heatedrivalry’]	0.979	497.909	0.0008		[‘viralvideo’, ‘fypviral’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.939	2.33	0.0008	
[‘billieeilishedits’, ‘edits’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.979	55.004	0.0006		[‘funny’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.939	2.33	0.001	
[‘shortnsweet’]	[‘sabinacarpenter’]	0.978	250.822	0.0009		[‘dexteredit’]	[‘dexter’]	0.938	241.397	0.001	
[‘hmhas’, ‘billieeilishedits’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.977	54.919	0.0011		[‘trend’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.938	2.327	0.0019	
[‘billieeilishconcert’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.976	54.886	0.0007		[‘trend’, ‘trending’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’]	[‘fyp’]	0.938	2.326	0.0006	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘foryou’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.974	54.733	0.0007		[‘fy’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.937	2.325	0.0017	
[‘hmhas’, ‘billieeilishedits’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.974	54.725	0.0007		[‘love’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.937	2.324	0.0007	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘foryou’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.973	54.72	0.0006		[‘fypage’, ‘viralvideo’, ‘viral’]	[‘fyp’]	0.936	2.323	0.0007	
[‘shanehollander’]	[‘heatedrivalry’]	0.972	494.686	0.0009		[‘fypage’, ‘fy’, ‘foryoupage’, ‘foryou’]	[‘fyp’]	0.935	2.32	0.0005	
[‘sabinacarpenteredit’]	[‘sabinacarpenter’]	0.972	249.095	0.0007		[‘f1tiktok’, ‘formula1’]	[‘f1’]	0.934	220.058	0.0006	
[‘billieeilishfan’, ‘billieeilishedits’, ‘fyp’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.971	54.577	0.0005		[‘formulaone’]	[‘f1’]	0.933	219.709	0.0006	
[‘billieeilishedit’, ‘foryoupage’]	[‘billieeilish’]	0.97	54.543	0.0007		[‘dextermorgan’, ‘edit’]	[‘dexter’]	0.932	239.691	0.0006	

Figure 4: The highest confidence association rules for Harris and Trump followers, depicted on the left and right, respectively.

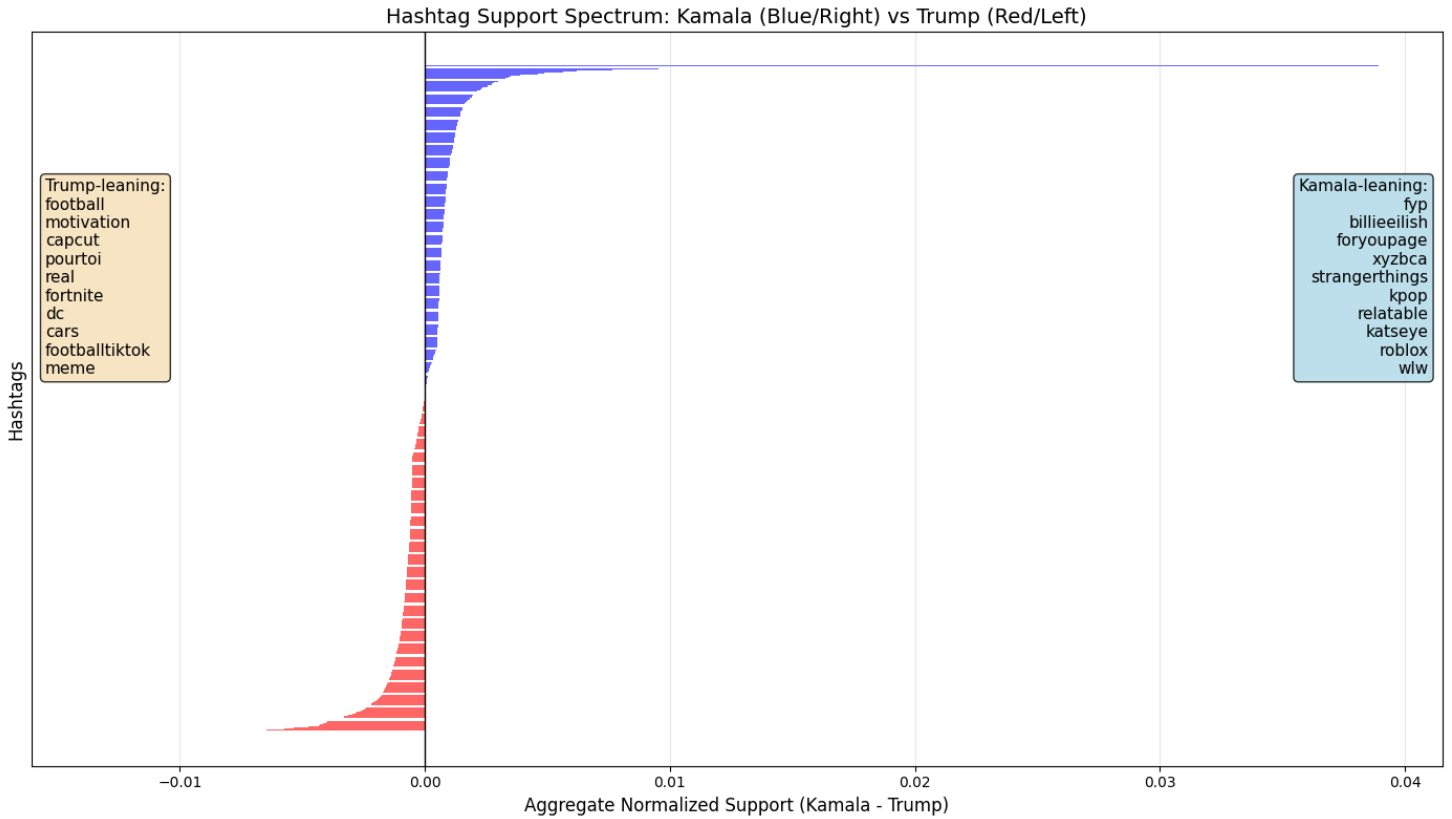


Figure 5: The distribution of differences between Harris corpus frequency and Trump corpus frequency for each hashtag. Positive differences indicate higher normalized frequency in the corpus of Harris hashtags, whereas negative differences indicate higher normalized frequency in the corpus of Trump hashtags. The hashtags with the ten highest magnitude differences for each candidate’s corpus are listed in the pale orange and pale blue boxes.

whereas ‘#strangerthings’,⁵ ‘#kpop’, and ‘#wlw’⁶ occur more frequently in Harris follower reposts.

However, turning to Figure 6, we see that the distribution of both confidence and lift of mined association rules is higher for Harris follower reposts than Trump follower reposts. The higher overall confidence suggests that the associations are more prevalent, while the higher overall lift connotes a unique association between consequent and antecedent. The implication is that on the whole, Harris followers have stronger and more consolidated association rules. This suggests that Harris followers may have more well-defined semantic and cultural communities than Trump followers, specifically regarding demarcation and separation of hashtag associations. Harris follower reposts are more likely to be specific

⁵ *Stranger Things* is a popular horror fiction television series set in the 1980s.

⁶ “WLW” is a common acronym for “women loving women.”

to a subset or community within Harris followers, whereas the contents of Trump follower reposts are more likely to have more general appeal and relevance across Trump’s follower base.

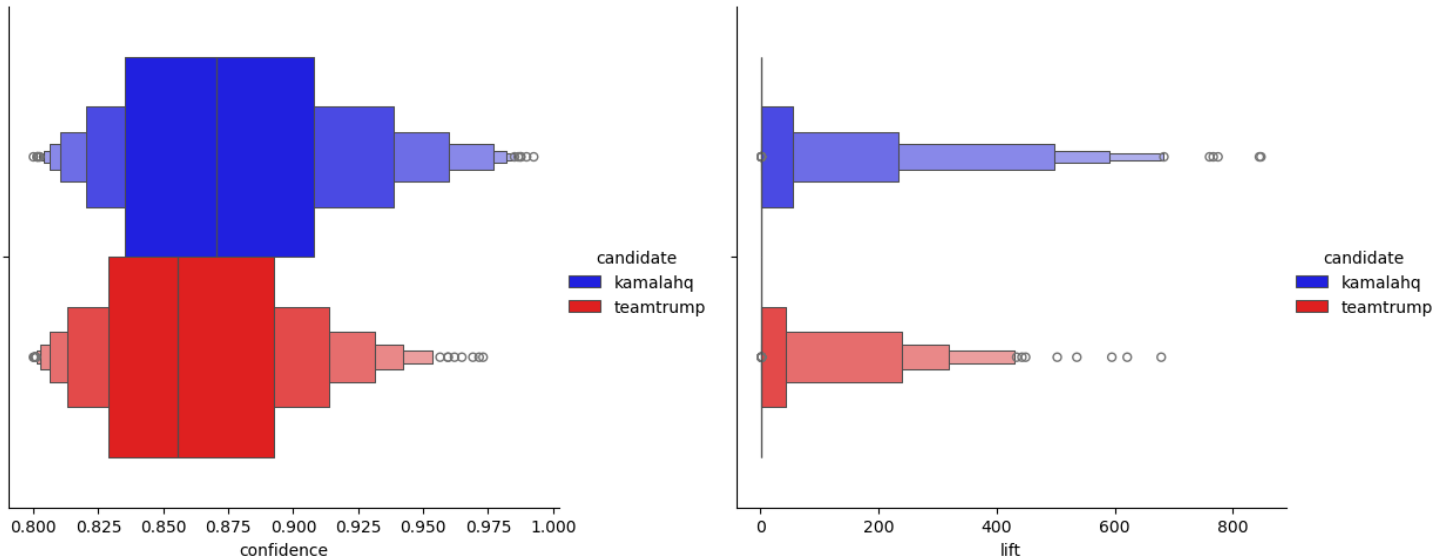


Figure 6: Boxplots displaying the distribution of association rule confidence and association rule lift on the left and right, respectively.

4.2 Hashtag Co-Occurrence Network Analysis

Pivoting now to the hashtag co-occurrence networks, we begin to find high-level structural patterns in the semantic discourse. A glance at Table 2 shows that the Harris network is larger, both in terms of nodes and edges as well as the diameter of the maximal component. This is in line with expectations, as there are more Harris follower reposts than Trump follower reposts. Interestingly, despite the fact that Harris followers had higher average hashtags per repost, as shown in Section 4.1, the Harris co-occurrence network has lower density.

Table 3 demonstrates that the Trump co-occurrence network, alongside being denser, has a higher average degree and higher average betweenness than the Harris co-occurrence network. This suggests that the semantic communities in the Trump co-occurrence network are more centrally concentrated and overlapping than those found in the Harris co-occurrence network.

As shown in Section 4.1, engagement hacking hashtags appear frequently in both Harris and Trump follower reposts, and this is corroborated by the high centrality measures of engagement hacking hashtags in the co-occurrence networks. Notice in Table 4 that several

Metric	Harris	Trump
Number of Nodes	487,200	246,620
Number of Edges	10,575,216	4,339,290
Density	$8.9106e - 05$	$1.4269e - 04$
Avg. Clustering Coefficient	0.8444	0.8453
Degree Assortativity	-0.0368	-0.0388
Diameter (Maximal Component)	11	9

Table 2: Network-level descriptive statistics for the Harris and Trump hashtag co-occurrence social networks. Average Clustering Coefficient and Diameter are approximated with built-in networkx approximation algorithms, and the numbers shown here is a lower bound for the true value. Note that edges are weighted by the number of co-occurrences for any two hashtags.

Metric	Harris Mean	Harris SD	Trump Mean	Trump SD	t-statistic
Node Degree	$8.91e - 05$	$1.21e - 03$	$1.43e - 04$	$1.48e - 03$	-15.57***
Node Betweenness	$3.38e - 06$	$5.42e - 04$	$6.93e - 06$	$8.06e - 04$	-1.972*
Node Pagerank	$2.05e - 06$	$7.40e - 05$	$4.05e - 06$	$9.60e - 05$	-9.082***

* $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$ *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3: Node-level measures comparing the Harris and Trump co-occurrence networks.

of the high betweenness hashtags for both the Harris and Trump co-occurrence networks are not engagement hacking hashtags, but instead refer to substantively informative topics. One might conceptualize these substantive high betweenness hashtags as common and far-reaching topics that bridge disparate semantic communities. For the Trump co-occurrence network, those hashtags are '#christmas', '#history', and '#sharinganeyes'.⁷ In the Harris co-occurrence network, these semantic bridges are '#art' and '#funny'.

While the two co-occurrence networks share similar average clustering coefficients and degree assortativity coefficient, the higher lift and confidence distribution for the Harris frequent itemsets in combination with a higher average node degree in the Trump co-occurrence network can provide an idea. These measures are consistent with Harris followers having more distinct, non-overlapping semantic communities and Trump followers having less distinct, overlapping semantic communities. While from a topological standpoint these networks resemble each other, the difference in node degree distributions suggests that the communities within the Trump co-occurrence network are more interlinked; in combination

⁷The phrase "sharingan eyes" is a pop culture reference that originates from the Japanese manga and anime series *Naruto*.

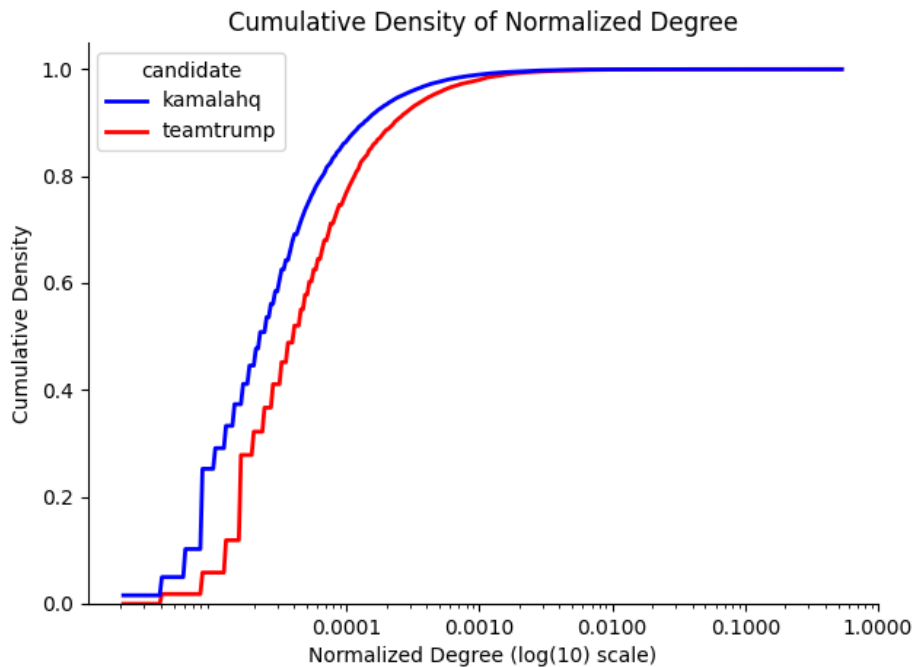


Figure 7: Cumulative density graph for normalized node degree distributions of Harris and Trump co-occurrence networks.

with the fact with the smaller network size, this can be interpreted to be that the Trump co-occurrence network is more coherent and connected than that of Harris.

4.3 BERTopic Bootstrap Models

After fitting 50 iterations of a BERTopic model on bootstrap samples from each corpus, I selected the model with the highest out-of-bootstrap-sample silhouette score that had between 15 to 30 topics. This range in acceptable number of topics is motivated by my desire to have enough diversity in topics to be able to identify stable themes but not so many topics that the topics themselves are not robust. Upon examination of these topic models, there are some emergent themes in the TikTok discourse for the two groups of followers.

Firstly, there is overlap in the broad categories of topics present in the Harris follower reposts and Trump follower reposts. For example, both of the topic models touch upon music, video games, and sports; however, within these broad categories, the preferences diverge. Trump followers seem to prefer country music, whereas Harris followers enjoy pop

Harris High Centrality Nodes					
Degree		Betweenness		Pagerank	
Hashtag	Value	Hashtag	Value	Hashtag	Value
fyp	0.5426	fyp	0.3516	fyp	0.0432
viral	0.2687	viral	0.071	viral	0.0163
foryou	0.2213	foryoupage	0.0684	foryou	0.0109
foryoupage	0.2196	foryou	0.0465	foryoupage	0.0109
fyp[smiley]	0.1600	fyp[smiley]	0.0365	fyp[smiley]	0.0070
edit	0.148	edit	0.0285	edit	0.0069
trending	0.1067	art	0.0245	relatable	0.0051
fyp[smiley]viral	0.0942	fy	0.0234	trending	0.0043
fy	0.0940	funny	0.0231	funny	0.0042
fypoooooooooooooooooooooooooooo	0.0915	goviraltiktok[heart]	0.0198	xyzbca	0.0037

Trump High Centrality Nodes					
Degree		Betweenness		Pagerank	
Hashtag	Value	Hashtag	Value	Hashtag	Value
fyp	0.4882	fyp	0.3755	fyp	0.0401
viral	0.2429	viral	0.0755	viral	0.0157
foryou	0.1943	foryou	0.0729	foryou	0.0104
foryoupage	0.1735	foryoupage	0.0428	foryoupage	0.0086
fyp[smiley]	0.1208	edit	0.0286	edit	0.0057
edit	0.1079	capcut	0.0275	fyp[smiley]	0.0054
trending	0.0937	fyp[smiley]	0.0225	relatable	0.0041
fy	0.0846	sharinganeyes	0.0195	trending	0.0038
funny	0.0754	christmas	0.0192	funny	0.0037
relatable	0.0753	history	0.0179	fy	0.0032

Table 4: Hashtags with high centrality in the Harris and Trump co-occurrence networks displayed on the top and bottom, respectively.

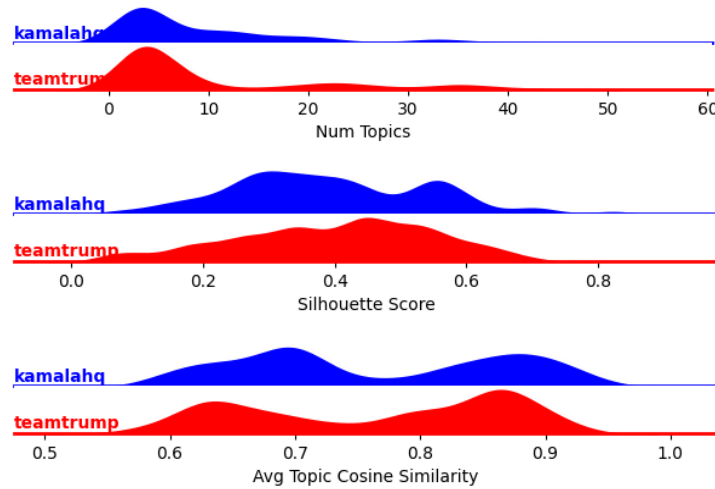


Figure 8: Distributions of various topic model measures across the 50 bootstrapped model iterations. Note that in BERTopic, topics are represented as vectors of n dimension, where n is the number of resulting dimensions from the implemented embedding model; in this case, the transformers embedding model produced 384-dimensional vectors.

and k-pop artists. Trump followers log onto games such as *Rust*⁸ and *R6*,⁹ while Harris followers opt for *Roblox*.¹⁰ While both Harris and Trump followers follow football,¹¹ Harris followers additionally enjoy volleyball, basketball, and dance.

There are also quirks that hint at some outlier reposts skewing topic representations. For example, Topic 1 in the Harris topic model is represented with the words "ceviche" and "need." Upon closer inspection, this is due to one of the representative reposts simply being the phrase "i need ceviche" repeated 264 times in succession. Interestingly, both topic models contain topics consisting of non-English language, which could point to an international follower base or perhaps a multilingual American follower base.

⁸*Rust* is a multiplayer open-world survival video game. The video game has come under fire for various controversies, perhaps most notably when the game randomly assigned skin color and gender to players' avatars and disallowed customization (Starkey, 2015).

⁹*Rainbow 6 Siege* is a multiplayer first-person perspective shooter video game.

¹⁰*Roblox* is an online video game platform that has gained popularity as a platform for players to create their own games.

¹¹Through examination of topics, I infer that "football" here primarily refers to soccer and rather than American-style football.

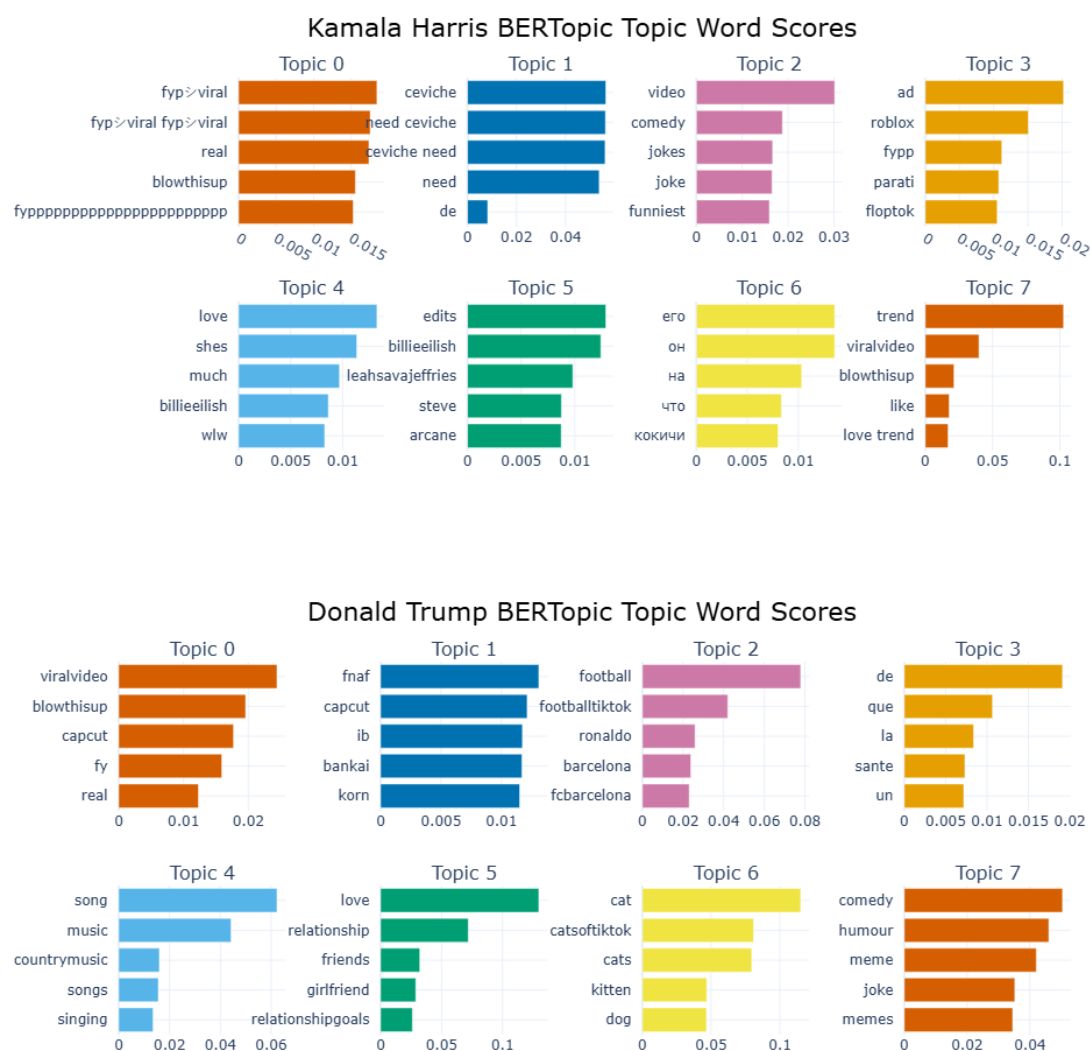


Figure 9: Tf-idf word scores for eight largest topics in each the Harris and Trump topic models depicted on the top and bottom, respectively. Models were selected based on silhouette score and number of topics.

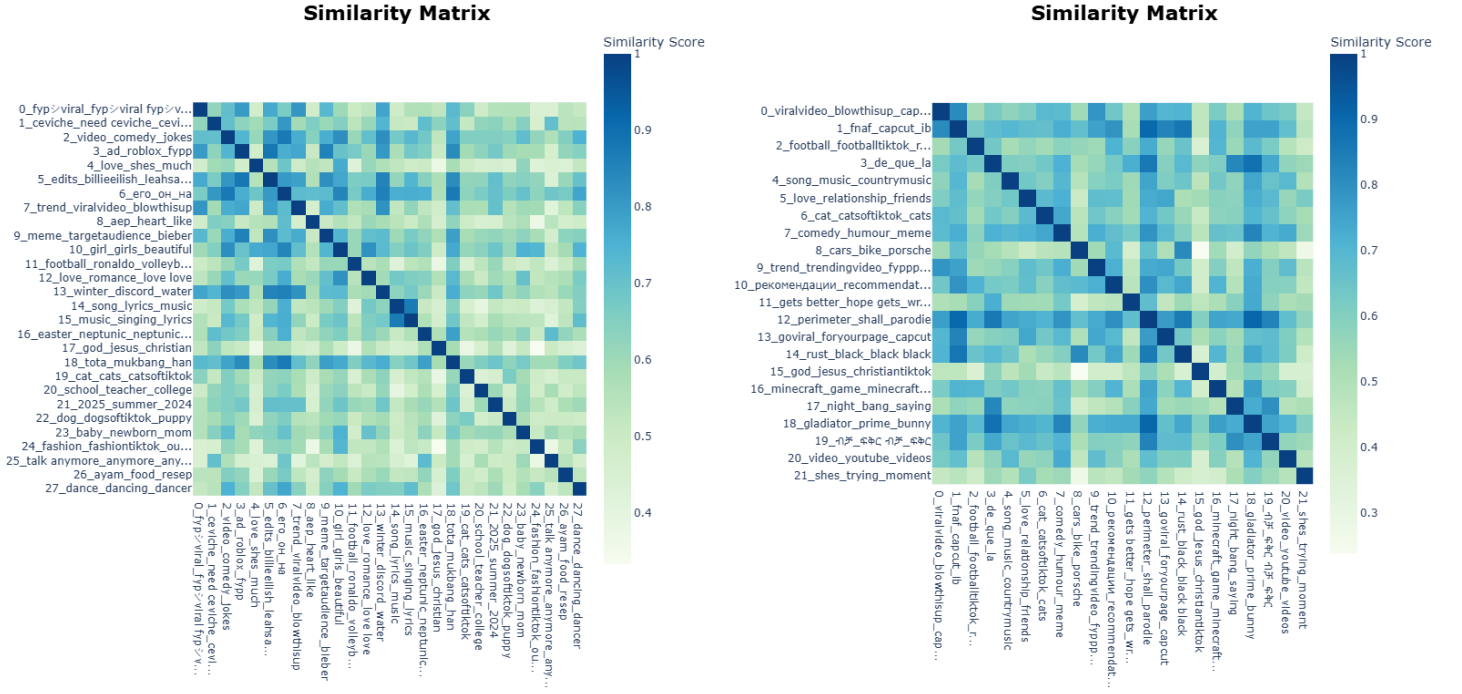


Figure 10: Topic similarity matrix for the two selected topic models for the Harris corpus and Trump corpus on the left and right, respectively.

5 Discussion

5.1 Structure and Relation

The higher density and higher average node degree for the Trump co-hashtag network suggests that the semantic communities are more largely overlapping and central rather than distinct and peripheral. This finding is consistent with previous literature that finds liberal cultures to be more demographically diverse (Rogers, 2022). We also see that for Trump followers, the most central hashtags in the co-occurrence network as well as the itemsets in the highest confidence association rules are largely dominated by engagement hacking hashtags. The most central hashtags and the most concretized associations amongst hashtags are uninformative, which obfuscates the substantive content of Trump followers’ reposts but also suggests that much of their cultural and entertainment preferences on TikTok are generic and non-specific. I use the descriptor “generic” here not to suggest broadness or range in the content reposted by Trump followers, but rather to indicate a lack of depth and specificity in the content, such that the most well-defined associations amongst hashtags and the most central hashtags deal primarily with engagement hacking.

This contrasts with the Harris co-occurrence network, as while both the Trump and

Harris co-occurrence networks share many of the same high-centrality engagement hacking hashtags, the highest confidence Harris association rules focus strongly on substantive, non-hacking hashtags. Namely, Billie Eilish features prominently in the Harris high confidence association rules. The few association rules that do not feature Billie Eilish still contain hashtags with substantive references to media and pop culture. Cultural communities found in the Harris followers’ reposts are more distinct from engagement hacking hashtags such that the associations of hashtags within communities can be identified in high-confidence association rules. Note again that although ‘#fyp’ occurs at a higher frequency in the Harris follower corpus than the Trump follower corpus, ‘#fyp’ is more prevalent in the high-confidence association rules for Trump followers, reinforcing the idea that cultural community structure of Trump followers’ reposts are largely organized around engagement hacking hashtags.

The breadth and diversity of semantic communities across follower bases is difficult to judge. On several measures, it would appear that Harris followers have wider breadth and greater topic diversity. The Harris follower corpus has roughly double the number of unique hashtags compared to the Trump follower corpus. The diameter of the maximal connected component in the Harris co-occurrence network is greater than that of the Trump co-occurrence network. Pivoting to topic modeling, the Harris topic model has lower average pairwise topic cosine similarity than the Trump topic model, indicating lower average semantic similarity across topics. If the difference in the reposting frequency holds consistent for the entirety of the two follower bases, it may well be true that Harris semantic communities have a wider breadth and greater diversity. This calls into question, however, the validity of interpreting the political-cultural divide through the lens of TikTok, and what kind of omissions or distortions of cultural and entertainment preferences are present—or rather, not present.

5.2 Themes and Culture in Content

There are firstly a few surprising patterns that Harris and Trump followers have in common. Both topic models reveal that a portion of the reposted content is in a non-English language, including but not limited to Russian, Spanish, and French. Romantic love and household pets such as cats and dogs show up in both topic models, establishing themselves as ubiquitous features of American life. Interestingly, Christianity and Jesus Christ also appear as a topic in both topic models. While literature shows that Christian nationalism is a driving force in American conservatism, specifically in rallying support for Donald Trump (Whitehead et al., 2018) (Baker et al., 2020) (Margolis, 2020), the presence of Christianity in both candidates’ topic models suggests that conservatism may imply Christianity but not vice versa.

The differences in the content reposted by Harris followers and Trump followers span across the categories. In music, we see that Harris followers prefer Billie Eilish, Sabrina Carpenter, and Katseye, while Trump followers enjoy A\$AP Rocky and Korn. Though both candidates' followers enjoy football, Trump followers additionally enjoy Formula 1 racing, while Harris followers are interested in dance.¹² Trump followers tune into *Dexter*,¹³ *Doctor Who*, and *Bleach*,¹⁴ but Harris followers prefer to watch *Heated Rivalry*, *Stranger Things*, and *Arcane*.¹⁵ In line with previous literature, my evidence strongly suggests that Democrats and Republicans do indeed exhibit different cultural preferences (Talaifar et al., 2025) (Deichert, 2019) (Lee, 2021).

One broad theme in Trump followers' reposts is violence in various formats and contexts. This violence presents itself across different topic categories; in sports, Trump followers discuss and enjoy UFC (Ultimate Fighting Championship), a martial arts competition league where professionals engage in controlled and precise combat. *Dexter*, a book and television franchise centering the eponymous serial killer, portrays the vigilante and righteous violence of a murderer targeting criminals. *R6* allows players' avatars to wield realistic firearms and imitate the violence enacted in military and police operations. Though the context and moralization, if any, of the violence varies across the relevant topics, the violence itself is central to the topic and furthermore appears as a recurring pattern throughout Trump followers' reposts.

On the other hand, closer examination of Harris followers' reposts reveals a robust connection to the LGBTQ+ community. Some terms and abbreviations referring to the LGBTQ+ community, such as "neptunic"¹⁶ and "WLW," appear in the Harris topic model. The television series *Heated Rivalry* centers around the intense and longing relationship between two closeted queer hockey players. *Arcane*, too, features a dynamic and complex relationship between two lesbian main characters. Billie Eilish herself is a member of the LGBTQ+ community, having both sung about and discussed her attraction towards women. This broad connection to the queer community and queer media suggests that a significant portion of Harris's followers are members of this community; at the very least, they make up a larger portion of Harris's followers than Trump's followers.

Gendered content becomes an emergent pattern of difference between Harris and Trump

¹²The documents in Topic 22, the topic in the Harris topic model that contains dance, contain references to k-pop, a music genre known for its complex dance choreography.

¹³The most recent screen adaptation of *Dexter* is *Dexter: Resurrection*, though it is not always clear which adaptation or installment of the *Dexter* franchise the reposts are referring to.

¹⁴*Bleach* is a Japanese manga series that has been adapted into an anime television series.

¹⁵*Arcane* is an animated television series based off of the canon of the video game *League of Legends*. Interestingly, *League of Legends* is nowhere present throughout my analysis of Harris followers.

¹⁶Neptunic is a sexual orientation defined as feeling attraction towards female-identifying and non-binary individuals. This orientation is distinct from other sexual identities such as gay or lesbian because the orientation is not defined by reflexivity and can be adopted by individuals of any gender.

followers. Across the board, Harris followers display affinity for content that centers around female celebrities or female protagonists, whereas Trump followers do not. For example, Topic 23 in the Harris topic model represent discussions about new motherhood, coining the nickname "momtok"¹⁷ to describe the community. In fact, Topic 10 in the Harris model is broadly about the word "girl." The music artists that Harris followers are interested in are primarily female, whereas Trump followers are interested in male artists. Harris followers enjoy sports that have more female representation, such as volleyball and dance, while Trump followers are interested in male-dominated sports, such as football and Formula 1 racing.

While gendered content is not completely indicative of the follower base gender distributions, a primarily female Harris follower base and primarily male Trump follower base are consistent with literature that show women are more likely than men to align with the Democratic Party (Barnes & Cassese, 2017) (Schneider & Bos, 2019). Known as the gender gap in politics, this divide in political attitudes of American men and women has been widening since the 1980s—and it seems to be enduring and present in the young audiences of TikTok.

5.3 Culture Mediated by Platforms

I mention at various points throughout this piece that Harris followers have reposted significantly more TikTok videos than Trump followers have. One potential reason could be that Trump followers have newer TikTok accounts and therefore less reposting history. Due to the constraints of the TikTok Research API, however, there is no way to confirm the date an account was created. The other possibility is that this difference in number of reposts is caused by difference in platform usage, which is consistent with literature on partisanship and social media (McClain et al., 2024). That difference in how much partisan users repost on TikTok is in and of itself a political-cultural division.

This struggle in understanding unexpected results points to the role of TikTok as a mediator between the user and the expression of political-cultural preferences. In the framework of my study, partisanship is reduced to following a major party candidate. I have limited my scope to just user reposts, but even still there are finite metadata that can be used to represent and interpret political-cultural communities and preferences. Yet, the communities and culture on TikTok are not just malformed and warped representations of the political-cultural divide off of social media; it is a new manifestation of these latent preferences, and TikTok is not just a mediator but a producer of culture. Memes, gifs, and trends take on a life unique to social media. The emergent digital culture resembles the broader offline

¹⁷It is not unusual for various communities on TikTok to replace the "Tik" in TikTok with another word to form a nickname. Examples include booktok, dancetok, etc.

culture, but it also incorporates communities and networks that are inherently tied to the social media platforms we use. The meaning of the hashtag '#edit' is not comprehensible without short-form video formats. "Momtok" does not exist without TikTok. Harris's "Brat" rebrand could not have been born anywhere else except on social media. While my findings are in line with previous literature on broader political-cultural patterns, culture and politics on TikTok are *sui generis* and exist in a capacity unique—and to some extent independent—from broader political and cultural norms.

6 Conclusion

I set out at the beginning of this piece to explore how cultural discourse varies in structure and contents across party lines on TikTok. To answer this question, I take presidential candidate accounts as a proxy for party and examine the TikTok videos that were reposted by followers of candidate accounts. To analyze the TikTok repost data, I employ frequent itemset mining, social network analysis, and BERTopic modeling. I find that the semantic communities in Trump followers' reposts are more overlapping and less distinct than those found in Harris followers' reposts. I find that Harris followers' reposts cover a wider breadth of topics. I analyze several emergent themes in the content of the reposts, finding connections to gender, sexuality, and violence. Finally, I examine how TikTok as a platform mediates and produces culture.

As politics, culture, and social media evolve, new and exciting possibilities follow. The continual production of culture and political attitudes will be guided by novel social media platforms and their defined modes for social interaction. Short-form video content is but one form of digital interaction; live-streams, 24-hour story posts, Tweets,¹⁸ and even fitness tracking apps are all avenues of social interaction that shape and reshape our political attitudes. Though the future of the political landscape remains unknown, it would be prudent to check the notifications on your phone.

¹⁸The social media site formerly known as Twitter, now X, retired the term "Tweet" in their rebrand. Now, X users simply post.

Data and Code Availability Statement

To reference the code and figures associated with this thesis, visit this [GitHub repository](#). In compliance with TikTok’s Terms and Conditions, I have not released the full dataset that I used for analysis; instead, I provide the Video IDs of all the reposts in my dataset along with the candidate associated with each repost in addition to the script used for scraping. These Video IDs can be used to query the TikTok Research API Tool and scrape all relevant metadata, including the metadata used in this study. For more information on accessing the TikTok Research API Tool, visit TikTok’s Developer Tools website [here](#). For replication purposes, the TikTok account @kamalahq has been renamed to @headquarters, and can possibly change again in the future.

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